

1985 ONWARDS

SPORTSWEAR

Although there is a long history of sports garments crossing over into mainstream fashion – late-18th-century tailored riding suits, for example – the fitness boom of the 1980s was the catalyst for a major crossover of sportswear into fashion. As the fitness centre became a social scene, exercise garb became stylish. At the same time, designers were experimenting with fabrics normally used for activewear. In 1980 American designer Norma Kamali created a collection entirely in grey fleece jersey; in 1984 American Donna Karan popularized the stretch bodysuit, and Tunisian-born Azzedine Alaïa designed Lycra dresses – a fashion revolution. Women's bodies were now shaping the clothes, rather than clothes shaping the body. Beyond the body-conscious trend, other sportswear styles have infiltrated fashion over the past few decades. The celebrity status of footballers and basketball players, coupled with a trend towards casual dress, has made athletic gear, especially footwear such as trainers, desirable. More recently, women demanded clothes that would take them from yoga, pilates, or running to shopping trips, coffee with friends, or even to work. This gave rise to “athleisure” clothes that are as fashionable for going out as working out.

TRAINERS



The obsession with sports footwear as fashion goes back to 1972, when Nike launched the Cortez, which became the trainer for the style-conscious in the newly emerging hip-hop music scene. Then in 1984, when women wore trainers with their suits to travel to work, Gucci became the first luxury brand to design a sneaker. But this was nothing compared with the buzz around the 1985 launch of the Nike Air Jordan I. Adidas followed in 1986, when their Superstar sneaker was made famous by rap-DJ group Run-DMC. Over the past few decades the big athletic brands have gathered a fanbase of “sneakerheads”, willing to spend a lot. Keen to create hot-selling trainers too, luxury brands began collaborating with “cool” people to create expensive trainers with street cred; for example, Louis Vuitton teamed up with Kanye West in 2009.

Jane Fonda's workout Jane Fonda was one of the personalities credited with spreading the aerobics craze and changing the idea of exercise gear. She released a bestselling book, video, and line of leotards and accessories (such as legwarmers) that became part of mainstream fashionwear.

Two-tone legwarmers

1985



Bright neon leotard

Decorative belt

Coat in style of horse rug

2001

Riding boots and bare legs for modern twist



Piping gives crisp edge

Saddle bag worn at waist

Head-to-toe branding

Basketball jacket with satin-look sleeves

2004

Black with green, team colours of Boston Celtics



Equestrian chic Riding clothes are a recurring source of inspiration. US designer Michael Kors' Autumn/Winter 2001 collection included jodhpur-style trousers and quilted field skirts, creating a new way of dressing based on active sportswear.

Basketball stars Converse basketball shoes were first manufactured around 1908. From the 1980s the sneakers became a fashion item, worn by hip-hop and rap stars, including Snoop Dogg, who used them as his style trademark.